enjoyed the words of the Leveller called William Erbery: ‘Fools are the wisest of men, and mad men the most sober-minded . . . If madness be in the heart of every man . . . then this is the island of Great Bedlam . . . Come, let’s all be mad together.’

It was a time of new ideas, energy, engagement. The idea of popular sovereignty over the Internet, of ‘teeming freedom’ arriving in that arena, was a way off and would still need to be fought for, and hard. I didn’t know it until later, but we could have called on Milton, who wrote a kind of saintly justification for civil disobedience and spoke of ‘a nation not slow and dull, but of a quick ingenious and piercing spirit, acute to invent, subtle and sinewy in discourse, not beneath the reach of any point the highest human capacity can soar to’.

We were neither so ambitious nor so capable, but we knew we were onto something that the world had never known before. From our own suburban bedrooms, we were seeking and finding a global computer network. ‘The whirlwind comes from the North,’ wrote one of the Levelling heroes. Well, maybe. But in a modern world turned upside down, we might call it the south, and give Australia its due. In any event, the energy we had was connected, if only unconsciously, to many a great, untold effort to wrest freedom from the arms of invisible power. Some of us might have been deluded enough to think the future would thank us – it wouldn’t. There were prisons waiting for such victims of delusion.

The real morning of revelation came not with the computer, but with the modem. When I got that, I knew it was all over. The past. The old style. Australia as it used to be and the world as it once was. Over. I was about sixteen years old when this fresh dawn came in a little box that dialled up really slowly. Before the Internet, the sense of a global subculture in computing worked through bulletin boards. These isolated computer systems would be set up in, say, Germany, and you would dial in and swap messages and software. Suddenly, we were all connected. There was always a problem with the cost of these international calls, of course, but some of our friends became experts at manipulating the phone lines. They were called phreakers. There is all this nonsense about the early computer hackers stealing from banks and so on: most of the hackers I knew were only interested in pulling back some free phone time. That’s as rich as they got; but what riches, to spend the night connected to all this overseas expertise. And the sense of discovery was fairly galactic.